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Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: No Date

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Not Specified

Section Title(S)

TERMS OF KINSHIP AND CORRESPONDING PATTERNS OF BEHAVIOUR AMONG THE THONGA

In the case of a first-born child, the maternal grandparents will come and *alula* the new-born baby: that is, they will welcome it by bringing presents of food and 10s. or a £1. This money will be handed to the paternal grandparents through the mother, and the food will be eaten with all the relatives present. The paternal grandparents on their side bring a goat, which is killed and eaten by the two families. The child when weaned is sent to the maternal grandparents to be brought up by them. The parents will send from time to time presents of food and clothes to assist the grandparents in the task of bringing up the child. This is called *ku dyisa ngwana* (to make the child eat). When it is grown up and able to work, if it is a girl, she will come back to the parent's kraal. A proof of the easy life first-borns have at their grand-parents village is that a mother will commonly say to her lazy daughter: "You don't know how to work, it can well be seen that you have been spoilt by your *bakokwana!*"

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It may be recorded here that a special pattern regulates the behaviour of my paternal and maternal grandparents towards one another. My paternal grandfathers call my maternal grandfather and grandmother, *masebe*, in the Khosen country (Portuguese East), *Ngwatsweku* or *Ntswalane* in the Transvaal. My maternal grandparents use the same term when addressing my paternal grandparents. The behaviour is of cordial and jocular familiarity. The men joke especially with the women of the other couple.

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(b) *The maternal uncles and their wives.*—Among the Ronga, Zulu, Sotho, Pedi and Venda, these uncles have the special name of *malume*. Thongas, of the Transvaal, under the influence of these tribes, use also the appellation of

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malume, but the proper Thonga term is *kokwana*. In this relationship, familiarity attains its maximum.

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It is not our intention to repeat here the excellent account given by Mr. Junod of the nature of the relationship between a *kokwana* and a *ntukulu*. (See Life, I, p. 231–233.) I shall only, as a complement to the description of this pattern of behaviour, give a typical account by one of my informants.

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